WORLD WAR II

SANTA CRUZ



Location Off Santa Cruz Islands, Solomon Islands

Date October 26,1942
Forces Americans: 2 carriers, 1 battleship, 6 cruisers, 14 destroyers; Japanese: 4 carriers, 2 battleships, 10 cruisers, 22 destroyers
Losses Americans: 1 carrier, 1 destroyer, c.80 aircraft; Japanese: c.200 aircraft

In October 1942 the United States had only two carriers, *Hornet* and *Enterprise*, operational in the Pacific. Rear Admiral Thomas Kinkaid, on board *Enterprise*, led them on a sweep north of the Santa Cruz Islands, searching for a Japanese naval force bound for Guadalcanal. The Japanese, under Vice Admiral Kondo, had the carriers *Shokaku*, *Zuikaku*, *Zuiho*, and *Junyo*, as well as a powerful force of battleships and cruisers.

On the morning of October 26, the opposing carriers located one another and launched air strikes. The first American and Japanese attack waves crossed in flight. The American attack put the carriers *Zuiho* and *Shokaku* out of action, along with the cruiser *Chikuma*. But the Japanese strike was more deadly. Combat air patrols failed to stop the Japanese dive-bombers and torpedo-bombers and the US carriers took a pounding. *Hornet* was hit first and worst. The Japanese struck her with bombs and torpedoes, and with two aircraft that, deliberately or not, crashed into the ship. *Hornet* was left dead in the water and on fire. *Enterprise*, initially hidden by a rain shower, soon came in for her own share of attention and suffered serious bomb damage. Many US aircraft were forced to ditch in the sea for lack of a deck to land on. Japanese losses of aircraft were, however, far heavier, for they pursued their attacks with relentless courage through a storm of anti-aircraft fire.

An attempt to take *Hornet* under tow failed as further waves of Japanese aircraft attacked. The carrier was eventually abandoned and finally sunk by a torpedo. For a short period after the battle, until *Enterprise* had been repaired, the United States had no aircraft carriers in the Pacific. Yet the Japanese had suffered such heavy losses of experienced pilots—148 aircrew killed—that they were in no position to exploit this temporary advantage.

Dive-bomber attack
A Japanese "Val" bomber dives on the USS *Hornet* during the battle of Santa Cruz. Seconds later the plane crashed into the *Hornet*'s signal bridge.



THE NAVAL BATTLE OF GUADALCANAL

In November 1942 the Japanese planned to turn the battle for Guadalcanal decisively in their favor by mounting a naval bombardment on the US airstrip at Henderson Field and landing thousands of reinforcements on the island. The operation would take place by night to avoid attack by aircraft from the airfield and the carrier *Enterprise*.

WORLD WAR II



GUADALCANAL

Date	November 12–15, 1942
Location	Off Guadalcanal, Solomon Islands
Result	American strategic victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES	JAPAN

COMMANDERS

Daniel J Callaghan **Willis A Lee**	**Hiroaki Abe** **Nobutake Kondo**

FORCES

Ships: 1 carrier, 2 battleships, 5 cruisers, 12 destroyers	**Ships:** 2 battleships, 8 cruisers, 16 destroyers

LOSSES

Men: 1,732 **Ships:** 2 cruisers, 7 destroyers	**Men:** 1,900 **Ships:** 2 battleships, 1 cruiser, 3 destroyers

On the night of November 12–13 Vice Admiral Hiroaki Abe led a force of two Japanese battleships and 12 smaller warships into "Ironbottom Sound" off northern Guadalcanal—so named for the number of ships sunk there. As usual, the Americans had forewarning of the Japanese movements and sent a force of five cruisers and eight destroyers to meet them. The Japanese and American ships blundered into one another in the dark and a brutal, disorganized fight broke out at close quarters—memorably described by one US officer as like "a bar-room brawl after the lights had been shot out." In the confused mêlée both Admiral Callaghan and his second-in-command were killed—the latter probably by "friendly fire." The Japanese battleship *Hiei* took significant damage, but the Americans suffered worse. By the time the Japanese disengaged only two US ships were still in a condition to fight. The next day the limping *Hiei* was attacked by American land-based and carrier aircraft and eventually scuttled.

ROUND TWO

Nothing could be done to stop the Japanese bombarding Henderson Field the following night, but by November 14–15 the Americans had brought a new force into play, consisting of the battleships *Washington* and *South Dakota* and four destroyers. This force encountered the advancing Japanese battleship *Kirishima* and 13 other ships shortly before midnight. The destroyers screening the American battleships performed their role courageously, but two were quickly sunk, a third so badly damaged it sank the following day, and the fourth disabled. Meanwhile *South Dakota* suffered electrical failures that left her exposed to a pounding from the Japanese guns. *Washington*, however, succeeded in stealing up on the Japanese unnoticed and hit *Kirishima* with a sudden devastating salvo that set the Japanese battleship ablaze. The night ended with the Japanese scuttling *Kirishima*. The battle doomed the Japanese plans to reinforce Guadalcanal. By November 15, seven transport ships had been sunk by air attack. The four remaining transports beached that morning and were quickly destroyed by American bombardment from air, land, and sea. The ultimate outcome was that the Americans could strengthen and supply their forces on Guadalcanal while the Japanese could not.



Japanese Naval Landing Forces helmet
Japanese attempts to land troop reinforcements on Guadalcanal were repulsed after two nights of naval fighting.

WITNESS TO WAR

COMMANDER CHIHAYA MASATAKA

OFFICER ON BOARD JAPANESE BATTLESHIP HIEI, NIGHT OF NOVEMBER 12–13, 1942

BATTLE OF GUADALCANAL

*"I think it was **about a minute** before I was due to give the order to **start bombarding** [Henderson Field] when, all of a sudden, the look-out on the bridge shouted out: "**Enemy ships starboard ahead" . . . I can still remember it**. There was no time to get permission from my commanding officer. I shouted: "**Change target! New target!** Enemy ships starboard ahead! Start bombardment with searchlights on!"… **The ships fought at close quarters**, almost falling aboard each other. We missed our antiquated rams very badly."*